After Hours: Building IRL Community

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Executive Summary

Young adults face various challenges with maintaining social connections after graduating. Without the platform of campus life, many struggle to find interesting events, overcoming attending events alone, and having a sense of community. Existing platforms such as Bumble, Meetup, and Nextdoor offer some tools but fall short when supporting real-life social engagement because of low transparency and weak accountability. Our group set out to understand and develop an application that can address the difficulties young adults have building relationships post-college. After Hours is a mobile platform our group made to mend the gap by applying behavioral design frameworks such as social translucence and social capital theory. These theories were used to increase trust and to help young adults to build confidence to engage with others in person. Through online interviews and usability sessions with low and mid-fidelity prototypes. Our research found key hesitation points: uncertainty with who will be attending the events, lack of support for communication, and fear of going alone.
Our results show a strong need for a platform that improves accountability, interest based events, and social cues. Participants found that personalized recommendations and group charts were needed. These findings made our prototype and made it centred around in real-life engagement, not keeping everything digitally.

Introduction

After graduating, adulthood can bring a shift in social infrastructure. Students who are used to university events, interactions made in classes, and the built-in community on campus often find it difficult to form new social relationships. Post-graduation brings challenges for young adults to maintain social connections. A lack of social connections causes anxiety, loneliness, and stress. Our project, After Hours, addresses the lack of post-college connections by creating a mobile application that encourages young adults to attend events by connecting with interest-based groups.

Related Work & Competitive Analysis

Insights from the literature focuses on online tools that must support social processes, not replacing them, to strengthen offline relationships. Prismack et al, performed a study relating to how social media usage can impact perceived social isolation and found that those in the upper quartile of social media usage had far more perceived social isolation than those who used social media less [9]. Social media in its current state isn't solving social issues but potentially exacerbating social loneliness.

Social translucence is the theory of social systems that "support coherent behavior by making participants and their activities visible to one another." [4]. And it relates to our project because socially translucent systems promote pro-social behavior in a way that existing social media has issues with doing. Note that this does not exclude privacy from being considered with our project as social translucence can be distinct from full transparency. Social activity on the internet is often considered as inherently difficult to understand and anti-social [4]. However,that doesn't have to be the case. Social media that's based around promoting personal interaction could be its own form of achieving social translucence not easily found through the internet.

Social Capital Theory is the theory of the resources gained through social interactions [3]. Naturally, social relationships can exist online, and social capital can be gained online through these relationships. Ellison et al state "our findings demonstrate a robust connection between Facebook usage and indicators of social capital, especially of the bridging type," in regards to the findings of their study of Facebook interactions [3]. However, it is also stated that "Our participants overwhelmingly used Facebook to keep in touch with old friends and to maintain or intensify relationships characterized by some form of offline connection such as dormitory proximity or a shared class" [3]. These connections online existed through relationships defined by real-world places and interactions. Social media does not have to be defined by increased social isolation, but in its current form, it often promotes opaque relationships, social isolation, and social capital-based relationships that could be better served through in-person interactions.

Literature Review:

Prior work in social-gathering centered apps and media has emphasized the need for social translucence and social capital in the digital world. Erikson and Kellogg talked about how social translucence is a design approach that makes users' activities visible to in turn support the flow of social processes in an online environment [4]. Beenen et al. introduced the idea that design principles such as reciprocity, reputation, and social identity can encourage participation online [2]. This ties into our idea to create a social gathering app because it provides insight into the specific techniques that will lead to the highest amount of interaction from users.

Taylor et al. write in their article about how people feel lonely but are not isolated, as well as the negative effects loneliness has on a person's health [13]. Hugh Malkin's article discusses event discovery and what companies can do to better show events to users. For example, companies that focus on niche events have an easier path forward in creating successes. Companies like Facebook that share better event information can help creators reach their audience [8]. Gruber et al. research how some elements of face-to-face interactions are lost in many forms of digital communication, and how these elements are translated into people's digital communication [6]. Sen et al. investigated how older adults use digital communication and how it can benefit their social well-being [12]. Primack et al. have worked on a study in which they performed a cross-sectional survey on young adults based on social media usage. They concluded that "Young adults with high SMU seem to feel more socially isolated than their counterparts with lower SMU" [9]. Hansen et al. did many studies on how digital tools can help people create social connections, which shows how technology can play a crucial role in bringing people together [7]. Ultimately, loneliness is a large social force that exists within young adults in the current generation, and the ability to generate in-person connections in a more seamless way can help mitigate that force.

One Foundational Framework that is relevant is social translucence, described by Erickson and Kellogg [4]. Their work argues that many online platforms fail to support natural social processes because they either block social cues or make users overly exposed. Social translucence proposes that systems should balance these extremes by fostering visibility, awareness, and accountability among participants. The goal of visibility is for participants to perceive others' actions, merged with awareness to help users coordinate with one another, and accountability to ensure that social norms can be enforced through the act of being observed. Barreto et al. made the point that designing technology to help show users what is going on socially around them can create sustainable online communities over time [1]. This is relevant to our project because our app aims to create a digital tool that ultimately strengthens real-world, in-person interactions. By adopting principles of social translucence, we can design features that make participation in events more visible (e.g, showing how many people have RSVP'd for an event), and reinforce accountability (e.g, verification systems and attendance histories to get verified), providing the foundation and guide for our design.

After Hours is positioned at the intersection of social isolation, effects of digital technology, and designing a framework for better socially oriented systems. This includes event-based and location-based social platforms. In this section, we review theories, prior systems, and empirical evidence that helps position *After Hours* in relation to the work.

Loneliness, Young Adults, and Digital Interventions

Ramo and Lim argue that digital tools can play a meaningful role in reducing loneliness among adolescents and young adults when their design intentionally guides users toward healthier relational patterns rather than sending users off to interact with passive consumption of content [11]. Their work emphasizes that technology should be leveraged to promote genuine connection, in particular tech tech-savvy or digital-savvy. This aligns directly with our project *After Hours*, which positions technology as a facilitator of in-person experiences rather than a replacement for them.

Social Capital and Online Networks

Ellison, Steinfield, and Lampe write about how bonds can be strengthened by integrating social capital to design; they help users maintain relationships, form new "weak ties", and are attentive to social cues that reduce interpersonal friction [3]. Their findings suggest that visibility and mutual awareness within a system encourages user participation and makes it easier for users to connect offline. This further emphasizes Putnam's broader argument that modern life has eroded human traditional community structures. He advises that new systems are needed to rebuild social capital in more contemporary ways [10]. Our design of *After Hours* responds to this need by including a structured, interest-driven approach with the goal of helping young adults form social connections after college.

Social Translucence as a Design Framework for AfterHours

In our design for *After Hours*, we used Erickson and Kellogg's framework of social translucence to provide a theoretical foundation for our design to support natural social processes [4]. They identify three key properties: visibility, awareness, and accountability. Applying these properties to the design to help users understand the actions of others without sacrificing personal boundaries. Gilbert wrote about how the more visible the social interaction is, the more connected and engaged users feel with their online community [5]. Designs such as RSVPs, attendance counts, and shared interest indicators(tags) to help users perceive emerging social activity around an event. This controlled visibility can reduce the uncertainty that often prevents individuals from attending events alone.

Insights from Prior Systems and Their Limitations

Across prior work, there is a consistent theme: digital systems that succeed at fostering social connection do so by making social cues visible, supporting low-pressure discovery, and enabling users to maintain or expand their offline networks. Some social networks, such as Facebook have done this broadly, but it is not optimized for more local, interest-based events among early-career adults.

How After Hours Ties It All Together

Integrating these perspectives, we have focused on these principles to inform *After Hours*:

1. **Use technology to enable offline connection** rather than substitute it [11].

2. **Build social capital by reducing social friction**, helping users see shared interests and overlapping social identities in communities [3, 10].

Leverage social translucence so users show their awareness when visibility is implemented of event-based community activity without compromising safety [4].

Limitations of Existing Platforms

Bumble BFF
The limitations with Bumble BFF is that it is designed for 1:1 friendship matching, not for people trying to discover or attend group events. Bumble doesn't have community-based events so users trying to find casual hangouts are unable to find group hangouts. Matches are also time-limited, so users may feel pressured to respond or forget, which can disrupt the flow of momentum to forming actual plans. Time limits are not always a good way to transition matches into in-person engagements. The nature of the application is structured in a way that does not facilitate event-based interactions. So users will have to go elsewhere to find more social community-based events.

MeetUp
Users may turn to MeetUp to find community-based events; however, there are barriers of entry issues affecting the usability of the application. One is the inconsistent fees, some of the fees are monthly based or event-based. Fee inconsistency may create some financial friction as well as discourage spontaneous participation. Young adults may be on limited budgets so financial stresses are an important factor. Another is inactive communities; this can reduce the trust people have on the platform.

Partiful
- Heavy reliance on the host
- Minimal accountability

Facebook Events
- Low transparency
- Limited trust and commitment

The Gap: Current platforms provide convenience when it comes to building online connections but lack a strong in real-life engagement, especially for individuals who are anxious and hesitant.

How After Hours Bridges the Space
After Hours builds on transparency, interest-based events, and accountability to:
- Reduce social anxiety when attending events alone
- Clear visibility to who is attending
- Support repeated in real-life interactions
- Build smaller interest-based groups

Methodology

Category	Details
Data Collection	We conducted a multi-method qualitative study focusing on young adults who avoid attending events alone.
Methods	6–8 one-on-one online interviews Usability sessions using the prototype Think-Aloud for real-time reactions Structured notes Recruiting through peers, group chats, and announcements
Interview Topics	How participants find events What discourages them from attending alone Features that could boost confidence Verification and visibility of online platforms
Tasks Assessed	Finding events Interest-based groups Attendance
Data Analysis	The team analyzed observation notes and Think-Aloud results using thematic grouping.
Results	Hesitation tied to uncertainty (“Will I fit in?”, “Who’s going?”) Need for accountability and reassurance Positive reaction to group chats and shared-interest indicators Preference for easy, intuitive navigation

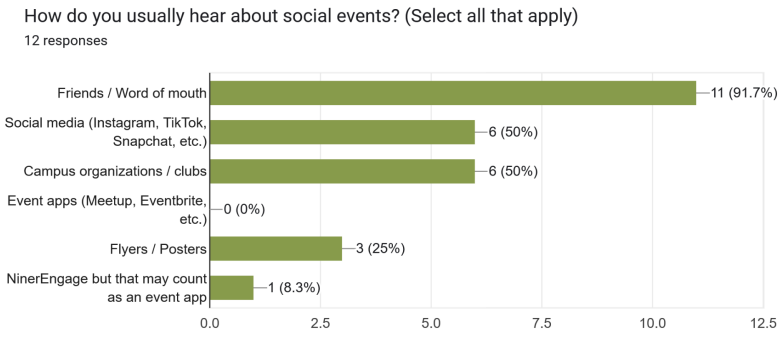

Figure 1: Ways students hear about social events

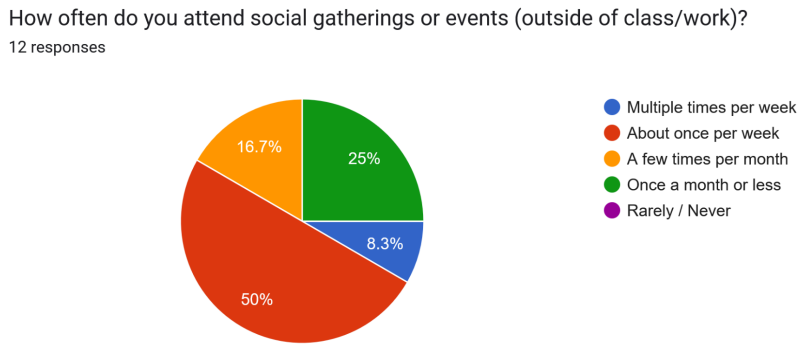

Figure 2: Rate of attending social events

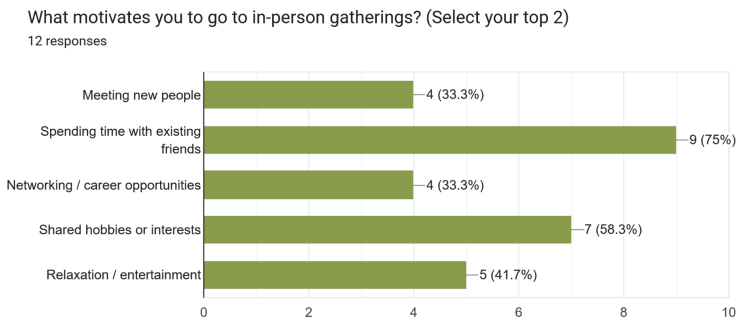

Figure 3: Motivations behind attending social gatherings

Results

[After Hours Figma Prototype Link]

Our prototype focuses on accountability, visibility, and building confidence.

Core Features:

Interest-Based Event Discovery

- Events were categorized by tags such as (music, art, fitness, etc.)
- Displays your tags, more events, and people that you know

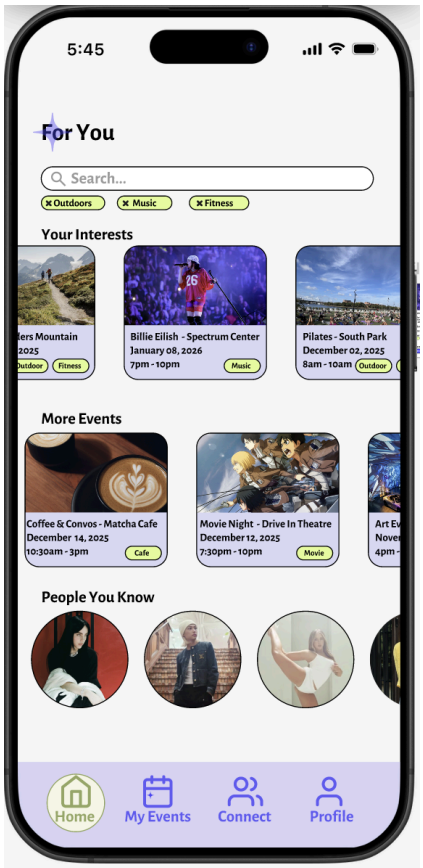

Figure 4: Home page for After Hours

Group Visibility & Accountability
- RSVP confirmations
- Profile badges
- Mutual Interest
- Attendee Lists

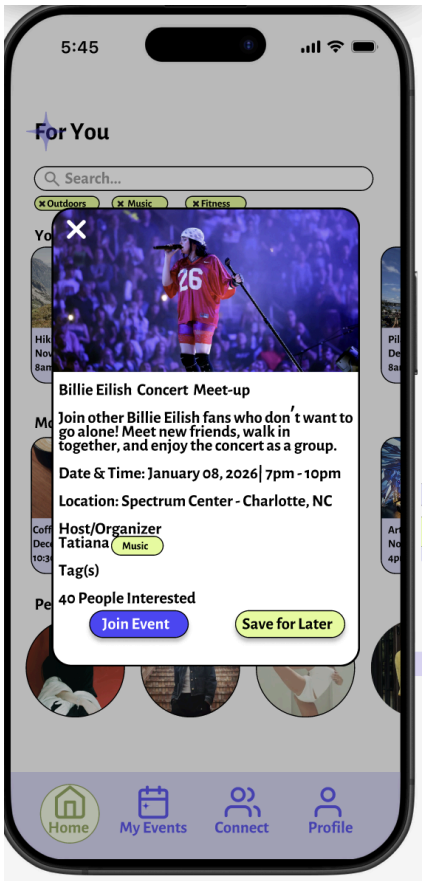

Figure 5: Event overview menu

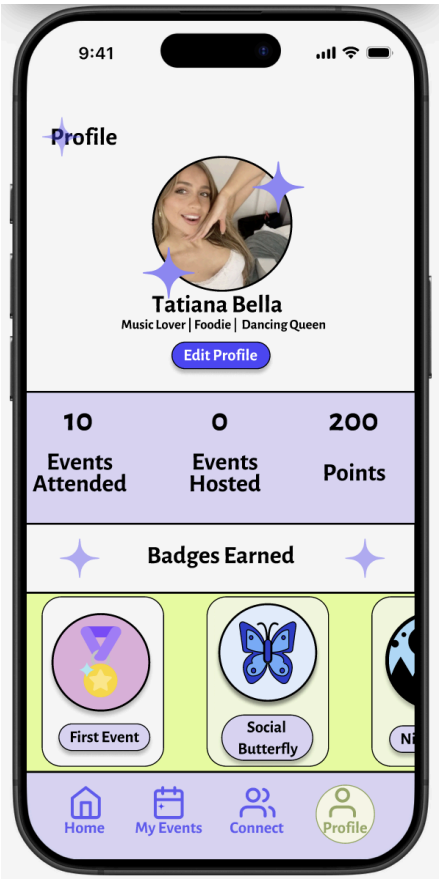

Figure 6: After Hours profile

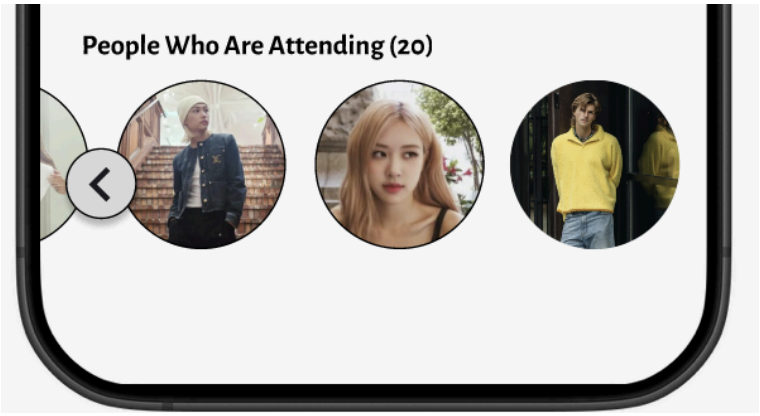

Figure 7: Event attendees display carousel

Real-Time Group Chat

- Participants can communicate before the arrival at the events to reduce social anxiety and to increase connections between individuals

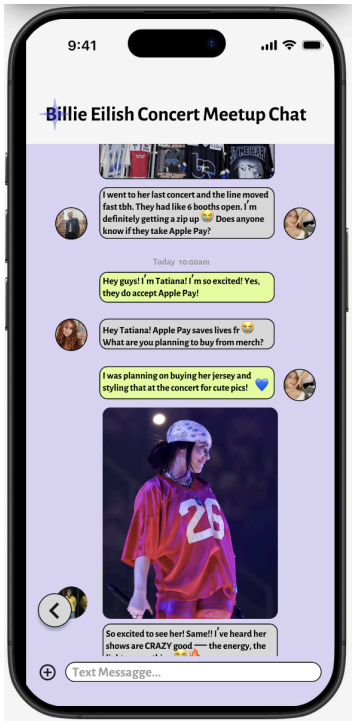

Figure 8: Event chatroom

Event Details

Clear expectations, host accountability, group size, and verification of the attendee

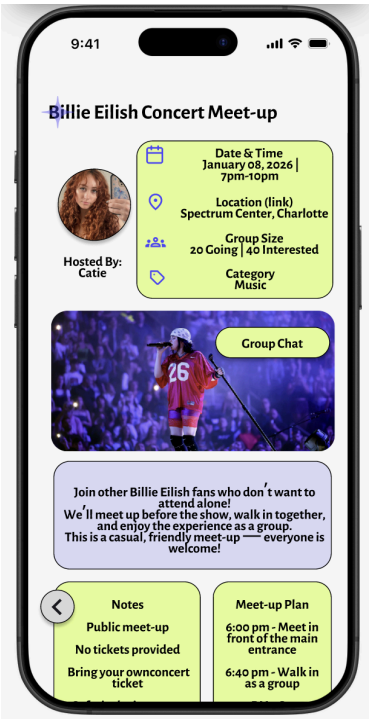

Figure 9: Full event profile

Opportunity Analysis

We found there is a strong opportunity for After Hours in the market. Young adults aged 18-25 struggle to make connections IRL, especially post-pandemic. Existing platforms pose significant gaps, including limited reach, low accountability, and inconsistent or confusing pricing. Our platform can fill this gap by providing reliable, transparent, and accessible event opportunities to young adults in a way that is safe and easy to use.

Discussion

Limitations

Privacy Concerns: With increased visibility, it could make some users feel uncomfortable. Tracking issues or data misuse.

Visibility: With increased viability, socially anxious individuals may be discouraged. This may also create subtle pressure to behave a certain way to maintain “ appearances.”

Engagement: In the beginning, interest may be strong, but after the spike, sustained events, notifications, and evolving features would need to be added so participation doesn't die out
Limited Testing: More testing needs to be done, with the interests being open to all, we need to test diverse experiences.

Future Work

Buddy Pairing: Pairing individuals who are attending by themselves with someone with similar interests to reduce the social pressure.

Advanced Privacy Settings: Includes profile exposure, location sharing,
Consistent Interest-Based groups: Long-term community that brings a sense of belonging so that it is not based on one event.

For You Page: A recommendation algorithm similar to what Meta employs for Instagram that can hone in on user preferences for events.

Alternative Event Views: Different options to view events near you, such as in the form of a map, a timeline (similar to a canvas dashboard), or in user-generated lists for recurring events.

Conclusion

The core problem of this project is to mend the post-college social isolation for young adults. The research we completed was helpful in pointing out what had already been discovered and accomplished. It also helped us to realize what had already been tried and failed. We learned that there is in fact, a link to online connections and the solution to loneliness. We conducted a survey that made it clear how people would feel when using an app designed to solve this problem by making in-person events easy to find. The people we surveyed were, for the most part, between the ages of 18-24 and had low rates of event attendance. They were open to the idea of an app intended just for events.

After Hours differs from other connection apps such as “Bumble BFF” or “Meetup,” because it focuses on common interests and brings those interests to life in-person. Often times, people struggle to find common interests when they are messaging one another on said apps, but with After Hours, you start with a common interest. The app features also allow you to create your own profile to keep track of the events you go to. This helps users connect based on real-life interests instead of strictly online ones. The app also features RSVPs for clarity, group chats for social connection, and verification for safety.

After Hours could create a broad change if it were to become successful. It could bring people back into the in-person community and create a third place for people outside of work and home. After this development, the next step would be to start developing the app and having people use it for social connections. This would hopefully allow people to spend more time with new friends in person and less time scrolling online. Although this app does start users online, it aims to push them offline and into social atmospheres. A successful use of this app would leave the user with many more friends and experiences in the end.

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